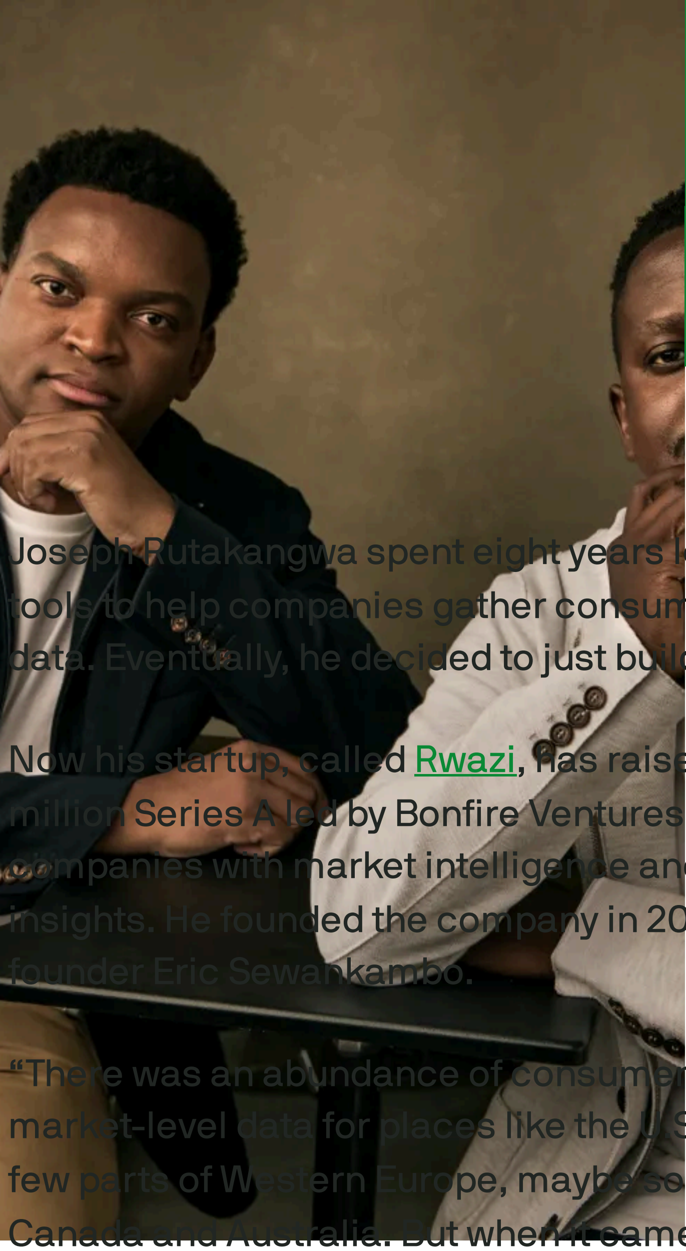
VENTURE

Rwazi raises $12M Series A to help companies with consumer insights and intelligence



Dominic-Madori Davis — 7:30 AM PDT · July 15, 2025

Joseph Rutakangwa spent eight years looking for tools to help companies gather consumer insight data. Eventually, he decided to just build them.

Now his startup, called Rwazi, has raised a $12 million Series A led by Bonfire Ventures to help companies with market intelligence and consumer insights. He founded the company in 2021 with co-founder Eric Sewankambo.

IMAGE CREDITS: RWAZI

"There was an abundance of consumer and market-level data for places like the U.S., U.K., and a few parts of Western Europe, maybe some traces in Canada and Australia. But when it came to international markets, including economic giants like India, Brazil, Mexico, Japan, Turkey, and China, there was nothing usable," he told TechCrunch. "No real picture on consumption, what consumers wanted, or how their behavior was shifting."

At first, he thought to solve the issue by purchasing statistics from government trade agencies. But eventually, he found that data to be outdated, fragmented, or sometimes simply nonexistent. He then turned to buying consumer reports and found them often inaccurate or hard to prove.

"The solution wasn't surveys. It wasn't panels. It was what we now call zero-party data; consumption data that's voluntarily shared by the consumer, within their own routines, captured using advanced validation and verification

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systems, across any location, in real time," Rutakangwa said.

Via their startup, the pair ended up building an AI-powered intelligence software system that lets businesses have real-time visibility into their consumer markets. It helps predict consumer behavior and identify important areas to pay attention to, which, in turn, can help reduce the cost of customer acquisition and boost customer loyalty. Rwazi customers include top consumer companies such as Coca-Cola, Pampers, Visa, and Nestlé, per Rwazi's website.

The company previously raised a $4 million seed round in 2022, also led by Bonfire Ventures.

Rutakangwa described the fundraising process this time around as "selective," saying he and Sewankambo focused on "finding the right partners, those who deeply understood the problem." Other investors in this round include

Santa Barbara Ventures, Newfund, and Alumni Ventures.

Rwazi said it will use the fresh capital to scale its AI co-pilot to help its clients make more accurate real-time decisions. It also hopes to hire more engineers. It currently pulls data from 190 countries, with customers primarily in the U.S. and Europe. The goal, as Rutakangwa said, is to continue building infrastructure that captures the evolving world of consumer data.

Rwazi does have competition, including from legacy consumer insights companies GFK and Ipsos. But Rutakangwa said Rwazi is different from its competitors because it doesn't rely on modeled or inferred data. Instead, its own infrastructure allows for insight and execution; knowing what to do and what to do about it, he continued.

"Winning today means anticipating shifts, seeing around corners, and making confident moves before the competition even senses a change," he said.

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Dominic-Madori Davis

Senior Reporter, Venture

Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

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IMAGE CREDITS: BOARDY AI

STARTUPS

AI networking startup Boardy raises $3M pre-seed

Dominic-Madori Davis

6:00 AM PDT · October 24, 2024

Boardy, a professional networking startup driven by AI voice technology, announced Thursday the closing of a $3 million pre-seed round.

The company was co-founded by its CEO Andrew D'Souza, Matt Stein, Shen Sivananthan, and

and has expanded since then. It is mainly used for people who are looking to meet customers and investors and has also helped people get into accelerator programs and get matched with co-founders, he said.

"If Boardy has spoken with someone he thinks would make a good connection based on both experience, as well as whether the two of you would actually get along, he will try and facilitate a double-opt-in introduction," D'Souza explained. If the introduction is accepted, then Boardy introduces both parties via email. "You can call Boardy back every week to work on a new introduction for you."

D'Souza said they started the company because of how lonely social media has made people. In fact, studies are now showing that America in particular is in the midst of a loneliness epidemic, which started even before the pandemic. D'Souza said there is a fear that AI will exacerbate the loneliness epidemic, taking jobs and displacing what makes people feel human.

While other startups are building AI-generated companions, sometimes with disturbing results, Boardy is using AI to facilitate human connections.

"We built Boardy to create a better future, where AI actually makes us more connected to each other and where humans and AI collaborate to solve humanity's hardest problems," D'Souza said.

Before this, D'Souza co-founded and led the e-commerce company Clearco. After almost 10 years at Clearco, he said the company grew to a size where they needed a more seasoned capital markets expert to lead the company. He willingly decided to leave as they brought on a new CEO, while D'Souza set forth on a new path.

Fundraising for Boardy was easy, as the round primarily consisted of investors D'Souza met through Clearco. HF0 was the largest investor in the round, with others participating, including 8VC, Precursor, Afore, FJ Labs, and NextView.

"Going forward, I hope to meet more of my investors through Boardy," he said.

Boardy will use the fresh capital to continue building and training the AI, hoping to make it smarter and more empathetic. The team is also working to expand Boardy's personal network to connect users with more people.

There aren't many competitors to Boardy at the moment, though there are companies building in the AI social networking space, such as Butterflies and SocialAI. There are AI companies to help consumers build agents and help with consumer interactions and booking appointments, though. D'Souza hopes Boardy is different, saying the AI agent "works for himself."

"You can ask Boardy for help and he'll do his best to help you, but not at the expense of other people in his network," he continued. "You can't tell Boardy what to do, which is actually what makes him more trustworthy."

This piece was updated to add the additional names of Boardy's co-founders.

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Dominic-Madori Davis

Senior Reporter, Venture

Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

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VENTURE

What will this year bring in VC? We asked a few investors

Dominic-Madori Davis

8:00 AM PST · January 4, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: LUDMILA CHERNETSKA / GETTY IMAGES

A new year brings with it hope for a better tomorrow — kind of, at least. In the world of venture capital, nothing is quite predictable. The number of firms in the U.S. has taken a sharp dip as risk-averse institutional investors splash money on only the biggest names in Silicon Valley, as reported by the Financial Times. AI is the only category that seems to matter, and that doesn't look to be changing anytime soon. But the new year has just started, and perhaps so has the impetus for change.

We spoke to some VCs to gather their predictions on the new year — the good, the bad, and what might end up being the unexpected.

Their responses have been edited and shortened for clarity.

What are your good and bad venture predictions for 2025?

Nekeshia Woods, managing partner at Parkway Venture Capital

The good: As wealthy individuals lower their return expectations for fixed income and cash equivalents, they will look more aggressively to private markets for outsized returns. This channel is expected to invest over $7 trillion in private markets by 2033. In response to this expected influx of capital, we have seen large wealth and asset managers use venture capital as a differentiating strategy among their private market offerings. These institutions have positioned venture to be a strategy where they can offer access to the best deals while capturing a portion of the $7 trillion expected to be invested in private markets through net new flows. Fund managers will simultaneously partner with these institutions to gain access to a new set of LPs that create a new, consistent, and long-term capital stream for their funds.

More good: We expect the AI field to start seeing consolidation, primarily through acquisition, in areas where AI can become a commodity, like large language models. The AI companies that will make it to be leaders in their field are opening new market segments and owning proprietary data.

Gabby Cazeau, partner at Harlem Capital

The good: The IPO market will fully reopen, and we'll see some big-name IPOs bring much-needed liquidity. That's a win for everyone. On the early-stage side, investment pacing will pick up, maybe not to 2021 levels, but certainly more than 2022-2024. It feels like 2025 will be a banner year for venture and *hopefully* the official start of the next bull run.

The bad: 2025 will be a make-or-break year for AI startups selling to enterprises. A lot of AI startups have grown quickly but are still stuck in the "experimental" phase, living on innovation budgets instead of being part of core software spend. Many won't make the leap, leaving a number of startups on the chopping block as churn and slow growth take over.

Triin Linamagi, founding partner at Sie Ventures

The good: The emergence of solo GPs and angel funds will drive increased investment into earlier-stage companies — a much-needed evolution for the venture capital ecosystem.

We'll see more specialized and well-defined investment approaches, with industry-specific, knowledgeable investors providing meaningful value to founders. This shift is not only beneficial for startups but is also likely to deliver better returns for investors. Capital allocation to diverse founding teams will continue to grow, particularly in sectors like sustainability and healthcare, where diverse perspectives can drive innovation and impact.

The bad: Meaningful M&A or IPO activity is unlikely until late 2025 as market conditions remain challenging. Limited partners will remain hesitant to deploy capital, waiting for improved distribution to paid-in capital metrics before committing to new funds.

Michael Basch, founder and general partner at Atento Capital

The good: Long-awaited increased liquidity for LPs with an opening of the IPO and M&A markets. More funds and companies taking secondaries as well. A reset of expectations of the zombie companies that are profitable not going to have the outcomes the VCs on the cap table underwrote, selling at a more grounded price to private equity. Consolidation and roll-ups in oversaturated spaces (e.g., GLP-1s).

The bad: Continued falling unicorns that have significant reset in valuations due to market resizing and growth expectations resetting.

Austin Clements, managing partner at Slauson & Co.

The good: IPO markets will reopen following the success of Service Titan, as will M&A activity for private companies. Finally realizing these gains will increase liquidity for the LPs behind many venture capital firms. This will lead to LPs committing to more new funds — more venture funds than in years past.

The bad: [LPs] may be more reluctant to commit to new fund managers after seeing a lot of undisciplined behavior in the last cycle. The unfortunate side effect is that some of the most innovative strategies will have a lot of trouble getting funded.

What are some trends that you think will remain? Which ones will go?

Woods

What will stay: Dealmaking will remain favorable to investors with dry powder. Investors will continue to move away from looking at products using [the] “number of users” as a key consideration and move toward booked revenues, client pipeline, and costs as key considerations prior to investing. The pace of investing will also maintain this investor-friendly environment. We do not expect venture firms to return to the frenzied pace of investing experienced for the past couple of years but instead continue with a balanced approach.

What will go: The outlook for IPO activity is moderately positive. Founder-renewed confidence in the public markets and comps coupled with dwindling cash runways and those high-valued companies that have survived the recent fundraising constraints, have right-sized their valuations to align more closely with the market. We believe that the consumer is also prime for investing in small-cap stocks, given the mega-cap technology stocks that have moved U.S. indexes into all-time highs and returned tremendous shareholder value. While there are still a number of companies whose valuations are not yet tracking to the market there are some, primarily in the tech space, that are ready for the public market.

Cazeau

What will stay: Small teams scaling revenue. We're seeing teams of just one to three people hitting $2 million+ ARR using AI tools — doing more with less and doing it better than ever. This kind of growth was unheard of before 2024 and highlights how much startups are automating internally with new software tools. The big question now is how these teams will scale and build strong organizations, but it's impressive to see such growth with such a lean setup.

We'll also see a resurgence in investment around reskilling — platforms addressing talent shortages in skilled trades, manufacturing, hospitality, healthcare, and other areas that software can't automate away.

Linamagi

What will stay: AI is here to stay. The widespread deployment of AI in 2024 marked a significant shift, and I believe this momentum will only grow. While it offers immense opportunities — such as enhancing decision-making, improving deal sourcing, and streamlining operations — it also presents challenges. For instance, human intuition and experience remain vital, particularly when evaluating founding teams and their dynamics. This evolution will require LPs to think more critically about how they select managers and construct their portfolios.

What will go: The spray-and-pray investment approach. I expect we'll see fewer deals but with greater diligence and meaningful value-add from investors. This trend, already evident in 2024, signals the end of the growth-at-all-costs mentality. Instead, investors will prioritize paths to profitability and sustainable business models, which will continue to be the hallmark of attractive opportunities.

Basch

What will stay: [The] perceived short list of winners in the AI space will continue to command significant investor attention at premium valuations. [There will be a] continued trend of VC-backed companies shuttering as capital markets [become] more selective in terms of funding [and the] continued trend [of] VCs, especially seed stage, [being] unable to raise new funds due to rough performing 2020 or 2021 vintages.

Clements

What will go: The last cycle was a deep shift to more investors backing enterprise SaaS companies and fewer backing consumer applications. I think this will start to reverse as AI creates more applications for consumers that just weren't possible a few years ago. Consumer tech will make a welcome comeback in 2025.

What is something unexpected you think could happen in 2025 in the world of venture and startups?

Cazeau

We could see mergers or even closures of some big-name unicorns, many of which have been industry darlings for years. These companies have just enough cash to make it to 2025, but not enough growth to go any further. We're already seeing some consolidation, and this will likely accelerate into 2025.

Linamagi

A significant climate-related disaster, geopolitical conflict, or economic shock has the potential to fundamentally reshape the startup and VC landscape.

Basch

A surge in venture dollars looking at hard technology, as software becomes commoditized due to generative AI. Hard tech as defined by bio, tech, hardware, other forms of deep tech taking center stage. [There will also be] a significant increase in companies raising only a seed round and having a sub-$100 million exit in sub-three years of existence — revealing a new math that could potentially work for founders and the VCs due to companies with distribution quickly acquiring top products that will complement their existing offering.

Clements

Something unexpected is that OpenAI could convert to a for-profit entity just for Microsoft to be able to acquire it in the largest acquisition ever.

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